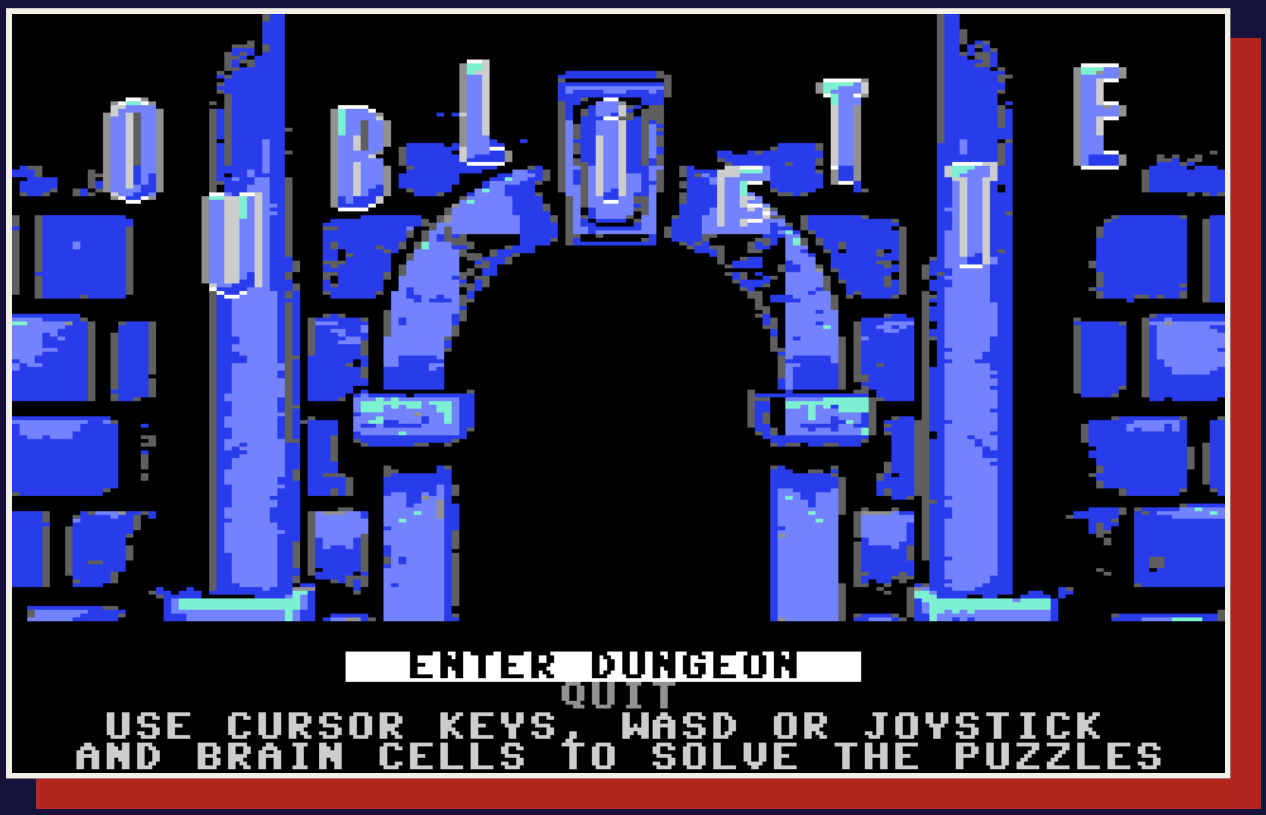
OUBLIETTE

SEVEN CELLS · ONE WAY OUT



7 DEADLY DUNGEONS

A PUZZLE IN EVERY CELL

Doors that move you, keys, hidden traps: each level has a trick of its own

MADE FOR THE VIC-II

Dan's pictures redrawn in multicolor bitmap graphics, with the C64's own colors

SID SOUND

Music for the title, the end and your demise, and sound effects from the 6581

Welcome, prisoner

Forgotten Below

An oubliette is a dungeon with only one way in: a trapdoor in the ceiling. **You have just come through it.**

The word comes from the French *oublier*, "to forget". The prisoners thrown into an oubliette were meant to be forgotten. Below your cell lie six more, each deeper and nastier than the last, and the skulls on their floors belonged to the people who tried before you.

Find your way out of all seven. There is no clock and nothing chases you: the only danger in the oubliette is **your own next step**.

What you need

- A Commodore 64 or 64C (PAL), or the VICE emulator (`x64sc`)
- An Ocean-type cartridge (`OublietteC64.crt`) **or** a 1541 disk (`OublietteC64.d64`)
- The keyboard, or a joystick in port 2

Loading the game

Cartridge: plug it in (computer off!), switch on, and the game starts at once. In VICE: `x64sc OublietteC64.crt`.

Disk: `LOAD"*",8,1` then `RUN` (the program is packed, so it loads in a few seconds). In VICE, just attach `OublietteC64.d64` and autostart.

In this manual

3 **Controls** — *keys and joystick*

4 **The dungeon** — *what you will find*

5 **Levels 1 to 4** — *chalices, doors, keys*

6 **Levels 5 to 7** — *locks and traps*

7 **Death and glory** — *and tips*

8 **Inside the C64** — *and credits*

Quick start

Press Return on the title screen, then walk with the **cursor keys**, W A S D or a joystick. Find what the level asks for, and reach the exit.

Hint

Thinking allowed

Each key press moves you exactly one cell, and the game waits for you as long as you like. Look at the whole level before your first step: most deaths come from hurrying.

Getting started

The controls

Four directions and a way out, on the keyboard **or a joystick**. *That is all you need, and all you get.*



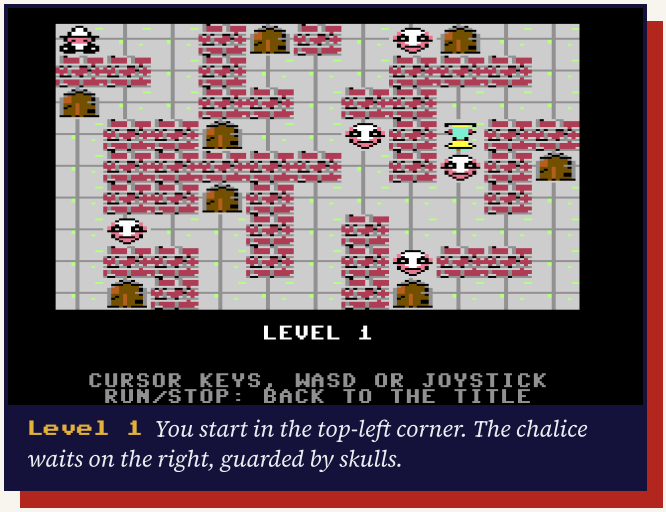
Title *Pick enter dungeon or quit, then press Return.*

On the title screen

Key	What it does
Any direction: cursor keys, W A S D, joystick	Switch between *enter dungeon* and *quit*
Return Space or fire	Choose
E	Enter the dungeon straight away
Q or Run/Stop	Quit (the computer starts again)

In the dungeon

Key	What it does
Cursor ↓ or S or joystick down	One cell down
Cursor → or D or joystick right	One cell right
Shift + Cursor ↓, W or joystick up	One cell up
Shift + Cursor →, A or joystick left	One cell left
Run/Stop	Give up and go back to the title



Level 1 *You start in the top-left corner. The chalice waits on the right, guarded by skulls.*

One step, one press

Each key press moves you one cell and turns the prisoner that way. Hold a key down and he keeps walking, step by step.

A joystick, in port 2

The joystick works like the keys: push to move one cell, and fire is Return. On the *continue?* questions, up is yes and down is no.

Know your cell

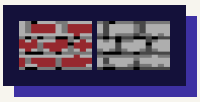
The dungeon

Every level is one screen of 11 x 9 cells, built from the same few stones. **Learn what each one does**: *it might keep you alive.*



You

The prisoner. One key press, one cell; you turn to face the way you move.



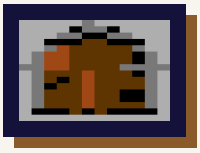
Walls

Red brick or grey stone, solid either way. You can't walk through them.



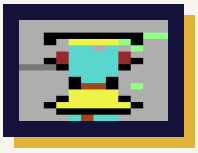
Skulls

Deadly. Step on one and you join it. Skulls never move, though.



Doors

Step in and you come out somewhere else in the dungeon. Not always where you expect.



The chalice

Pick it up and the way out shows itself.



Keys

Keys open what is locked: a wall, or a door that won't let you through.



The exit

Walk onto it to reach the next level. On some levels it appears only when you have earned it.



The unseen

Some things in the oubliette look like something else, and some can't be seen at all.

Doors are a map

A door usually sends you to the same place every time. Note where each one leads: a sketch on paper of the doors and where they lead is the surest way through the later levels.

Beware

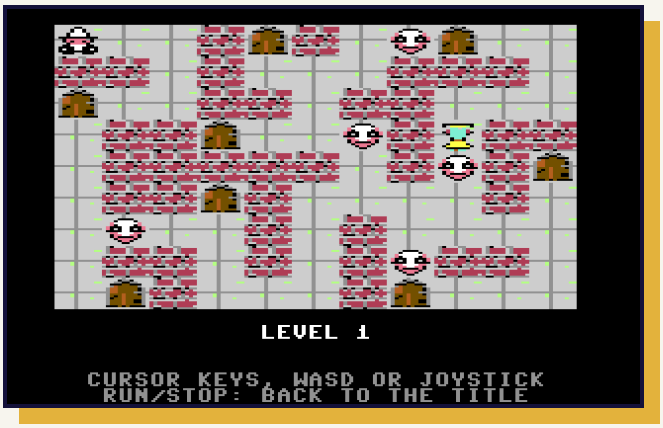
Look before you leap

A door can drop you right next to a skull, or right onto another door. Before stepping in, think about where you will come out.

Going down

Levels 1 to 4

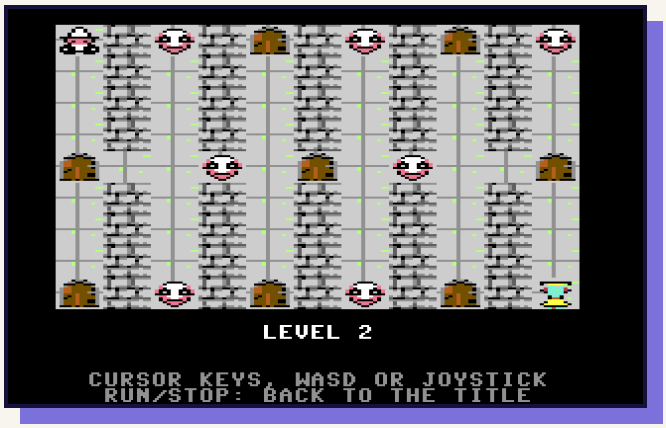
Every level adds one new idea. **Here is what changes**; *how to get out, you work out.*



1 The first cell

New: chalice and doors

Find the chalice, and the exit appears. The doors connect parts of the dungeon that you can't walk between. Try them, and remember where each one leads.



2 Two exits

New: an exit that isn't

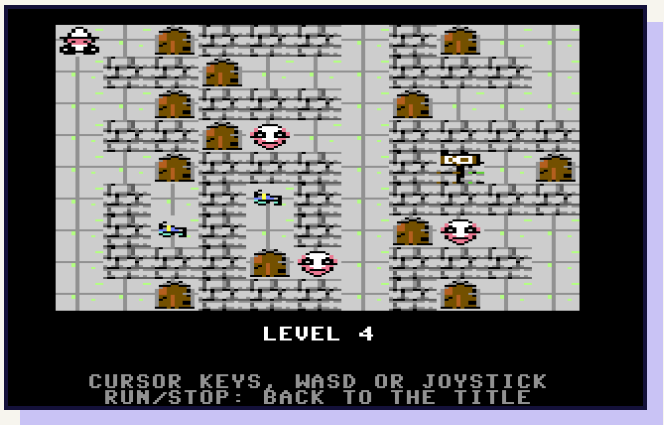
The chalice shows you an exit, but it isn't the last one. Something changes once you have been there.



3 A maze of doors

New: doors onto doors

Twenty-two doors. A door can drop you onto another door, which sends you on again. Plan a chain of jumps, not single steps.



4 Two keys

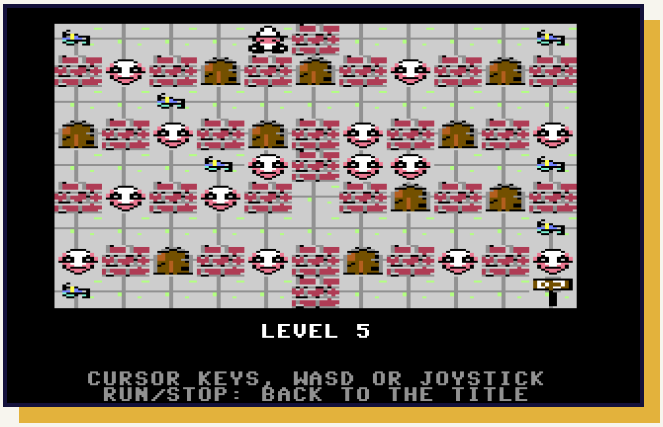
New: keys

The exit is already painted on its wall, but the wall stays shut until you are carrying both keys.

Deeper still

Levels 5 to 7

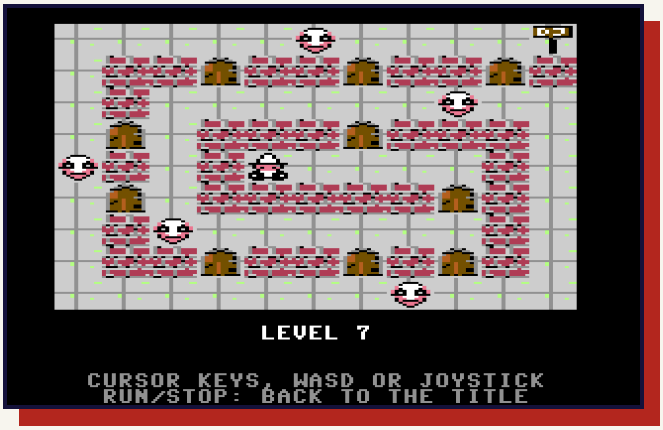
The exit is in sight from the start now. **Getting there is another matter.**



5 Locked doors

New: locks

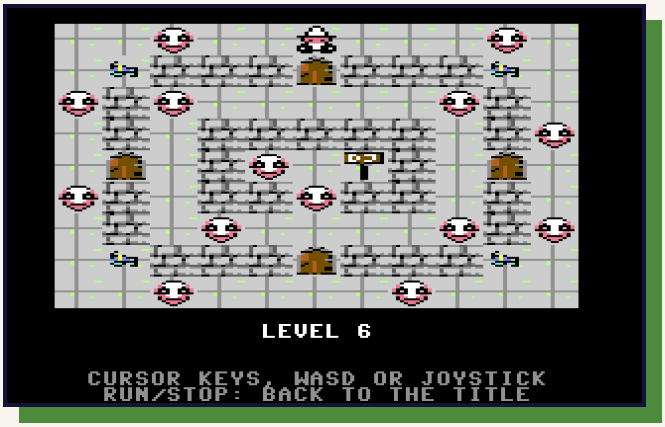
The exit waits in the bottom-right corner, but locked doors stand in the way. Every key you pick up unlocks one particular door. A door that leads nowhere simply opens when you step through it.



7 The last cell

New: trapdoors

You start in the middle, and the exit is in the top-right corner. Only one door here is really a door: the others are trapdoors, and they kill you. Each true door you pass through shows you the next.



6 The ring of skulls

New: hidden places

Four keys and four locked doors guard the exit in the middle. There are more skulls than paths, but some floor tiles hide something that clears a skull away. Walk where nothing seems to be.

Level 7

A door, or a trapdoor?

They look exactly alike. Watch the dungeon closely after each door you use: what is new on the screen is where to go next.

Stuck?

- Look for what has changed since you started: a door, an exit, a missing skull.
- Try every door once, from a safe place.
- Run/Stop and a fresh start cost you nothing but the level you were on.

The end of the road

Death and glory

Sooner or later, the dungeon claims you. **You have as many tries as you need.**



Demise *Step on a skull or a trapdoor and the giant skulls come for you, with a gloomy tune.*



Freedom *Climb out of the seventh cell and the dungeon is mastered, to a bright fanfare.*

Dying, and trying again

The lose screen asks `continue? y/n`:

- `Y`, `Return` or joystick up (or fire): try the same level again from its start. You keep the levels you have already cleared.
- `N`, `Run/Stop` or joystick down: back to the title.

Winning

Out of the seventh cell, you are free, and the win screen asks `continue? y/n`:

- `Y`: throw yourself back in, from level 1.
- `N`: back to the title.

Tips from the bottom of the pit

- Skulls never move, and nothing chases you. Take all the time you need.
- A door usually sends you to the same place every time, so it pays to map them. *(Usually.)*

- When a level looks impossible, look again: something has changed, or something is hidden.
- `Run/Stop` always gets you out. You lose nothing but the level you were on.

Behind the stones

Inside the C64

Dan wrote Oubliette in Applesoft BASIC for the Apple II. **This is the same game**, *with its rules carried over, on the machine with the best sound chip of its day.*

7
levels, with the same maps and rules as the original

160x200
multicolor bitmap: black and 3 colors in each 4 x 8 cell

3
SID voices: melody, harp and bass

6502
assembly language: no BASIC, no KERNAL

What changed from the original

- The IIgs art, redrawn for the C64: the board's tiles are 12 x 16 multicolor pixels, and the prisoner is drawn by hand. The pictures use the C64's own palette, so the title is bright blue and the skulls grey and brown.
- Music for the title, the lose and the win screens, and seven sound effects, played by the SID: a bell for a new level, a creaking door, a ghostly wail.
- The pictures are packed (LZ4, 14K instead of 26K) and a raster interrupt switches from graphics to text under them. A black row under each picture hides the switch.
- Cursor keys, W A S D and a joystick, all at once.

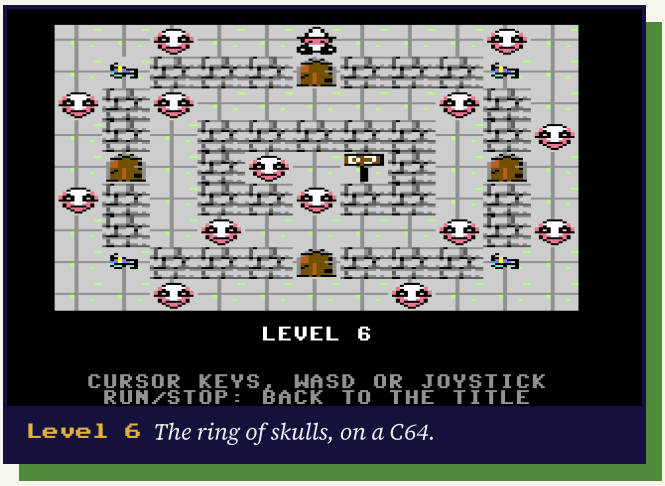
What did not change

- The seven levels, their doors and teleports, keys, hidden traps and trapdoors. Automatic tests play the C64 game against the same model of the rules: every level with its solution, and thousands of random key presses.
- One step per key, and "continue? y/n".

Credits

GAME DESIGN, THE APPLE II VERSION AND THE GRAPHICS
Dan Henderson

COMMODORE 64 VERSION, MUSIC AND SOUND EFFECTS
Walter Tengler



Level 6 *The ring of skulls, on a C64.*

"Out of the darkness I came. I hath mastered the dungeon."

Seven levels, no saves, no mercy.